

states GUJARAT

Modi's dream of a third term as chief minister could be spoilt by enemies from within as BJP rebels join hands with the Congress

■ By Uday Mahurkar

With elections to the state Assembly less than five months away, the BJP in Gujarat should have been rallying its forces behind Chief Minister Narendra Modi who is virtually the party's mascot in the state. To the contrary, Modi is in for some anxious moments as he faces revolt from sections of his own party, backed by former Gujarat chief minister Keshubhai Patel, a known Modi-baiter. This motley group, comprising nine suspended party MLAs and three MPs, is openly siding with the Congress, while accusing Modi of being dictatorial and anti-poor. Most of them seem to be camouflaging their personal ambitions behind the mask of an ideological debate. Though some of these leaders are set to join the Congress, others are rudderless as to what course of action they should take.

The rebel group, dominated by the Patels—who have been Modi's biggest bugbear ever since he replaced Keshubhai as the state chief minister—and led by Ahmedabad MLA Gordhan Jhadaphia shows no signs of letting up even after discreet interventions by the BJP high command, which is alarmed by the rebellion brewing within the party on the eve of the elections. Last week, they held their 56th meeting at Junagadh and floated a new outfit called the Sardar Patel Utkarsh Samiti whose only agenda seems to be Modi baiting. The group is certain that they will succeed in tearing apart the Modi magic. Says Jhadaphia, "Modi's game is up. By the time we complete our targeted 102 public meetings, his rural base would have been completely eroded. We will then target the urban areas."

For the moment, the rebel leaders are camouflaging their private

SPLIT WIDE OPEN: The rebels have floated a new outfit called the Sardar Patel Utkarsh Samiti



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